

D566

Psychology of Learning

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	_____	

Items

1.

A child who lives in a blue apartment building gets a painful shot at a clinic where the nurse always wears a lavender-scented lotion. After several visits, the child starts crying as soon as she smells lavender, even at a friend's house. Her older brother plays soccer. In this example, what is the conditioned stimulus?

- A. The smell of lavender.
- B. The blue apartment building.
- C. The painful shot.
- D. Crying at the smell.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

After the child in a conditioning example smells lavender many times with no shots, her crying at the smell fades. What is this called, and what caused it?

- A. Forgetting, since all learned responses fade with time alone.
- B. Generalization, caused by similar smells.
- C. Spontaneous recovery, caused by time passing.
- D. Extinction, caused by the CS appearing repeatedly without the US.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

A driver whose car is painted bright red buckles her seat belt to stop the car's loud beeping. Over time she buckles up immediately every time she gets in. She drives to work on a toll road. Which process increased her buckling?

- A. Negative punishment.
- B. Classical conditioning.
- C. Positive reinforcement.
- D. Negative reinforcement.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A teen loses phone privileges for a week after breaking curfew, and breaks curfew less often afterward. Which process is this?

- A.** Negative punishment.
- B.** Positive punishment.
- C.** Negative reinforcement.
- D.** Extinction.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5.

A casino that recently renovated its lobby offers slot machines that pay out after an unpredictable number of plays. Players keep playing long after losing streaks begin. The casino also offers free parking. Which schedule explains this persistence?

- A.** Fixed ratio.
- B.** Continuous reinforcement, which always builds the strongest habit.
- C.** Variable ratio.
- D.** Variable interval.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Students in a class have a quiz every Friday and study little on Monday through Wednesday but heavily on Thursday. Which schedule produces this pattern?

- A.** Variable interval.
- B.** Variable ratio.
- C.** Fixed interval.
- D.** Fixed ratio.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7.

A new medical assistant who drives a hybrid car watches a senior colleague calm an upset patient with a specific de-escalation technique. She pays close attention and can describe every step afterward, but she has never practiced it and freezes when she tries. The clinic has three exam rooms. Which step of observational learning is missing?

- A. Attention.
- B. Reproduction.
- C. Motivation, since learners who watch closely always perform.
- D. Retention.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8.

Two students who share a dorm with a view of the quad each have 6 hours to study for a final exam in four weeks. Student A studies 6 hours the night before. Student B studies 1.5 hours once a week for four weeks. Both use the same flashcards. Which prediction is best supported?

- A. They will do equally well, since total time is the same.
- B. Student B will retain more because distributed practice improves long-term memory.
- C. Student B will do worse because 1.5 hours is too short to learn anything.
- D. Student A will retain more because the material is freshest.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9.

A nursing student who works weekends at a coffee shop has 30 minutes left to prepare for a pharmacology exam. She has already highlighted the chapter in three colors. Which use of her time will most improve long-term recall?

- A. Add a fourth highlighter color for key terms.
- B. Copy her notes word for word.
- C. Reread the highlighted sections slowly.
- D. Close the book and answer practice questions from memory, then check answers.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10.

A 9-year-old who has two younger sisters loves drawing and spends free time sketching. Her school starts paying students \$1 per drawing. When the program ends, she draws much less than before. The school recently added a new playground. What best explains the drop?

- A. Extinction of a response that was never reinforced before.
- B. The overjustification effect: the external reward undermined her intrinsic motivation.
- C. Rewards always increase motivation, so something else must explain it.
- D. The new playground distracted her.

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer ____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
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11. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A manager wants volunteers who already enjoy mentoring to keep doing it for its own sake. Which approach best protects their intrinsic motivation?

- A. Offer no feedback of any kind.
- B. Rank mentors publicly by sessions completed.
- C. Give informative, unexpected recognition of the difference their mentoring makes.
- D. Pay a set amount per mentoring session.

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer ____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
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12.

A surgical resident who runs marathons is learning a complex new procedure. Her attending tells her that if she makes one mistake she will be removed from the program, and the hospital board is watching. The operating room was recently repainted. What does the arousal-performance relationship predict?

- A. Her performance will likely suffer, because very high arousal impairs complex tasks.
- B. Her performance will improve, since more pressure always helps.
- C. Her marathon training will keep her calm enough to perform best.
- D. Pressure matters only for simple tasks, not complex ones.

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer ____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
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STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer A Concept 1

A child ~~who lives in a blue apartment building~~ gets a painful shot at a clinic where the nurse always wears a lavender-scented lotion. After several visits, the child starts crying as soon as she smells lavender, even at a friend's house. ~~Her older brother plays soccer.~~ In this example, what is the conditioned stimulus?

Target word: identify the CS **Decides:** The once-neutral cue that now triggers crying.

A	Correct	A neutral smell that, after pairing with the shot, now triggers fear.
B	Camouflage	Never paired with the shot.
C	Confusion set	The shot is the unconditioned stimulus—it causes pain without learning.
D	Adjacent category	That is the conditioned response, not the stimulus.

2. Answer D Concept 1 • transfer

After the child in a conditioning example smells lavender many times with no shots, her crying at the smell fades. What is this called, and what caused it?

Target word: name the process from the result **Decides:** CS presented repeatedly without the US.

A	Absolute language	Extinction is new learning that the CS no longer predicts the US; time alone is not the cause.
B	Adjacent category	Generalization spreads a response to similar cues; it does not reduce it.
C	Inverted operation	Spontaneous recovery is the return of a response after extinction, not its fading.
D	Correct	The learned link weakens when the pairing stops.

3. Answer D Concept 2

A driver ~~whose car is painted bright red~~ buckles her seat belt to stop the car's loud beeping. Over time she buckles up immediately every time she gets in. ~~She drives to work on a toll road.~~ Which process increased her buckling?

Target word: operant process **Decides:** Behavior increased by removing an unpleasant stimulus.

A	Confusion set	Punishment decreases behavior; buckling increased.
B	Adjacent category	The behavior is voluntary and shaped by its consequence.
C	Inverted operation	Nothing pleasant was added; something unpleasant was removed.
D	Correct	Removing the beeping increases buckling.

4. Answer A Concept 2 • transfer

A teen loses phone privileges for a week after breaking curfew, and breaks curfew less often afterward. Which process is this?

Target word: operant process — decreasing behavior **Decides:** Something pleasant was removed and the behavior decreased.

A	Correct	Removing a pleasant stimulus to decrease a behavior.
B	Inverted operation	Positive punishment adds something unpleasant; here something was taken away.
C	Confusion set	Reinforcement increases behavior; curfew-breaking decreased.
D	Adjacent category	Extinction stops a reinforcer for the behavior; this removes an unrelated privilege.

5. Answer C Concept 3

A casino ~~that recently renovated its lobby~~ offers slot machines that pay out after an unpredictable number of plays. Players keep playing long after losing streaks begin. ~~The casino also offers free parking.~~ Which schedule explains this persistence?

Target word: schedule most resistant to extinction **Decides:** Reward after an unpredictable number of responses.

A	Confusion set	A set number of plays per payout would be predictable.
B	Absolute language	Continuous reinforcement extinguishes fastest.
C	Correct	Unpredictable reward per response produces high, persistent responding.
D	Adjacent category	Based on time passed, not the number of plays.

6. Answer C Concept 3 • transfer

Students in a class have a quiz every Friday and study little on Monday through Wednesday but heavily on Thursday. Which schedule produces this pattern?

Target word: schedule from the response pattern — reverse direction **Decides:** Reward available after a set time; responding bunches before it.

A	Confusion set	Surprise quizzes would produce steady studying.
B	Inverted operation	Would produce steady, high responding, not a pre-deadline burst.
C	Correct	A predictable time schedule produces a burst just before the reward.
D	Adjacent category	Based on number of responses, not days.

7. Answer B Concept 4

A new medical assistant ~~who drives a hybrid car~~ watches a senior colleague calm an upset patient with a specific de-escalation technique. She pays close attention and can describe every step afterward, but she has never practiced it and freezes when she tries. ~~The clinic has three exam rooms.~~ Which step of observational learning is missing?

Target word: missing step **Decides:** She attended and retained but cannot perform.

A	Dropped element	She watched closely; attention is present.
B	Correct	She lacks the practiced ability to carry out the behavior.
C	Absolute language	Watching closely does not guarantee performance; here the gap is skill.
D	Confusion set	She can describe every step, so she retained it.

8. Answer B Concept 5

Two students ~~who share a dorm with a view of the quad~~ each have 6 hours to study for a final exam in four weeks. Student A studies 6 hours the night before. Student B studies 1.5 hours once a week for four weeks. ~~Both use the same flashcards.~~ Which prediction is best supported?

Target word: retention outcome **Decides:** Same total time, distributed vs. massed.

A	Dropped element	Ignores how the time is arranged.
B	Correct	Spacing the same 6 hours produces better retention.
C	Wrong stem number	Focuses on single-session length; $1.5 \times 4 = 6$ hours total, distributed.
D	Inverted operation	Cramming feels fluent but fades faster.

9. Answer D Concept 6

A nursing student ~~who works weekends at a coffee shop~~ has 30 minutes left to prepare for a pharmacology exam. She has already highlighted the chapter ~~in three colors~~. Which use of her time will most improve long-term recall?

Target word: best study strategy **Decides:** Active recall beats review.

A	Camouflage	Builds on the highlighting detail; highlighting is a low-benefit strategy.
B	Adjacent category	Passive transcription involves little retrieval.
C	Confusion set	Rereading builds familiarity, not durable recall.
D	Correct	Retrieval practice strengthens memory more than rereading.

10. Answer B Concept 7

A 9-year-old ~~who has two younger sisters~~ loves drawing and spends free time sketching. Her school starts paying students \$1 per drawing. When the program ends, she draws much less than before. ~~The school recently added a new playground.~~ What best explains the drop?

Target word: effect of external reward on enjoyed activity **Decides:** An expected reward for an already-enjoyed activity.

A	Adjacent category	Drawing was intrinsically rewarding before the payments.
B	Correct	She came to see drawing as done for pay; when pay stopped, so did much of her interest.
C	Absolute language	Expected rewards can reduce intrinsic motivation.
D	Camouflage	Irrelevant detail; the timing matches the end of the payments.

11. Answer C Concept 7 • transfer

A manager wants volunteers who already enjoy mentoring to keep doing it for its own sake. Which approach best protects their intrinsic motivation?

Target word: choose the approach that avoids overjustification **Decides:** Avoid expected, performance-contingent rewards for an enjoyed task.

A	Dropped element	Removing all feedback drops the competence support that sustains intrinsic motivation.
B	Adjacent category	Adds external, controlling pressure.
C	Correct	Unexpected, informational feedback supports competence without shifting the reason for acting.
D	Inverted operation	An expected, contingent reward is what triggers overjustification.

12. Answer A Concept 8

A surgical resident ~~who runs marathons~~ is learning a complex new procedure. Her attending tells her that if she makes one mistake she will be removed from the program, and the hospital board is watching. ~~The operating room was recently repainted.~~ What does the arousal-performance relationship predict?

Target word: performance under high arousal on a complex task **Decides:** Complex task plus very high arousal.

A	Correct	Complex tasks peak at lower arousal; extreme pressure pushes her past the optimum.
B	Absolute language	Past a moderate point, arousal hurts performance.
C	Camouflage	Endurance fitness does not decide arousal effects on a complex task.
D	Inverted operation	Complex tasks are more sensitive to high arousal, not less.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	3	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	1	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	9	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	7	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	5	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	7	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	4	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Classical conditioning components	An unconditioned stimulus (US) naturally triggers an unconditioned response (UR); after pairing, a neutral stimulus becomes a conditioned stimulus (CS) that triggers a conditioned response (CR). Presenting the CS repeatedly without the US leads to extinction.	Labeling the response by what it looks like rather than by what triggers it.	A once-neutral cue that now produces an automatic reaction.
2	Reinforcement vs. punishment	Reinforcement increases a behavior; punishment decreases it. "Positive" means adding a stimulus, "negative" means removing one.	Treating negative reinforcement as a form of punishment.	Does the behavior go up or down, and was something added or taken away?
3	Schedules of reinforcement	Variable-ratio schedules give high, steady responding and are most resistant to extinction; fixed-interval schedules produce a burst of responding just before the reward is due; continuous reinforcement is fastest to learn and fastest to extinguish.	Believing rewarding every response builds the most durable habit.	Rewards after an unpredictable number of responses vs. a set time.
4	Observational learning	Learning by watching requires attention, retention, reproduction (ability to perform), and motivation; seeing a model rewarded (vicarious reinforcement) increases imitation.	Assuming a learner who watched closely will automatically perform the behavior.	A learner watching a model, then acting—or not—later.
5	The spacing effect	Spreading study sessions over time (distributed practice) produces better long-term retention than the same total time in one block (massed practice).	Trusting cramming because it feels fluent right after the session.	Same total hours arranged differently.
6	Retrieval practice	Actively recalling information (self-testing, practice questions) strengthens long-term memory more than rereading or highlighting.	Mistaking familiarity from rereading for durable learning.	A choice between testing oneself and reviewing notes again.
7	Intrinsic motivation and the overjustification effect	Offering an expected external reward for an activity a person already enjoys can reduce their intrinsic motivation once the reward stops.	Assuming adding rewards always increases motivation.	A person who loved an activity loses interest after being paid for it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
8	Arousal and performance	Performance rises with arousal up to a moderate point, then falls (an inverted U); the optimal level is lower for complex or unfamiliar tasks.	Believing more pressure always improves performance.	High stakes plus a complex task.

Course scope (public description): Psychology of Learning focuses on applying research on learning, emotion, and motivation to positively impact influence human behavior. The course presents a study of key research and theories in the areas related to learning, with a focus on applications to promote acquisition, retention, and transfer of knowledge. Learners will explore evidence-based strategies to promote learning and analyze how individual and group characteristics can impact affect learning. This course will improve learners' understanding of the emotional, social, and environmental factors which that shape human learning and humans' capacity for development. "Introduction to Psychology" is the prerequisite for this course.